Artist's Statement

Artist's Statement

This course forced me to overcome the hesitance and fear of writing poorly, with prompts that I wasn't comfortable with or even styles of writing. I think I have developed that creativity of just being able to write. Even more helpful was workshopping, I really had to overcome that social fear of people reading my writing.Though I lacked greatly in my Notebook of Noticings, the few times that I did write spontaneously, I realized how much I missed keeping a journal with me everywhere to document ideas or brief pieces of fiction. Specifically, there was a moment in class-completely unrelated to the Notebook of Noticings-that I got a spark of creativity and started drafting one of my poems. Throughout this course, I was realizing how important it is for me to write creatively, especially as an English major. While I have not always experienced this passion consistently and where I have been recently stuck in a stagnant relationship with reading and writing, the spark has reignited.

While I loved the non-fiction section of this course and might have begrudgingly liked poetry, the fiction section was where I caught myself truly stimulated in my writing. While I do not doubt that poetry and non-fiction are places of creativity, I felt like it was easier to build ideas from nothing in fiction. For example, I attempted to write about a character who has a strong aversion to meat while I myself am the complete opposite. In this section of fiction, I was able to disconnect my personal voice from my writing. I used to be able to call myself a writer when I was in middle school, I was writing short pieces of fiction every single day. Over time, it was becoming difficult for me to step out of the constant writing slump that I usually got when I was lacking creativity. I connected greatly with my flash fiction in a way that I was passionate about taking my original creativity and making a story of it.

The revision process was facilitated for me by the time I spent away from my own writing. Starting fresh again not only allowed me to read my own writing a bit more critically but new ideas were inspired off the page. An assignment I struggled to compose was the place based essay, I remember reading the prompt and just being stuck. I originally put in very little effort because it was difficult to write about something so personal. Because I had so much to develop and improve for revisions, I ended up enjoying the process of writing the essay way more than I had initially. Since I had less than a page of a draft, I decided to completely rewrite the piece. Whereas some revisions were easier the more I felt I had to improve, for other projects it felt like cleaning up rather than rebuilding. In my short story and poems, I was really focused on clarity and re-wording but not necessarily changing execution of my themes.

I went into this course with the goal of "just having fun". As I mentioned previously, I was feeling discontented with writing creatively and I wanted to be able to enjoy it again. When I am able to find joy in things, it's easier to learn and improve because there is that motivating desire. While I was "just having fun" in this course, I did notice significant improvements in my "story telling". Starting out with the epistolary was a great way to get into describing a story even though it was not fiction, it prepared me for the actual fiction section of the course. My singular goal was met and that branched out to other technical writing achievements and I am glad to see that reflected in my portfolio.

Non-Fiction

I’ll have the usual: Bears, UHauls, and a side of Stan

I can’t talk about the Farm without talking about the customers. I could write a novel about the Farm, but I can only spare a few stories that keep me up at night. We open on May 1st for plants and flowers, but we have plenty of people who confuse us for Market Basket and ask me why we don’t have tomatoes yet. This is the most nettling but average customer that visits us for the short season of Spring into Fall.

Teddy Bear Man was new this year. He walked in with two vintage teddy bears in his arms, the brown fuzzy ones with black beads for eyes. He offered me one for five hundred dollars in slurred words. I asked him to repeat himself, but I heard him right. He asked me if I wanted to hold them, but with my refusal, he left them on the counter and began shopping. Teddy Bear Man only comes in when I’m working and conveniently when my coworkers are busying themselves. According to my old employer, a potential camera in the bear was probably the least strange thing about the stuffed bear. Though, Teddy Bear Man isn’t as bad as the UHaul guy when I was freshly sixteen but still appealing to someone grown with forehead creases.

He was my first exposure to being anything but a man in the outside world. As a successfully sheltered child, the experience was like a plunge into ice water. There was a certain gaze in his eyes that made me want to shrivel into myself; I assume a rabbit feels similar when a hawk soars above. I recall his eyes following my movements, ready to strike as I wrapped brown paper around his two pounds of sweet, Spring honey. My coworker was not near enough to hear what he was telling me as he smiled. When he began to make his way toward his truck, I wasn’t exactly sure how to put what was happening into words. She sensed my discomfort and told me to go to the bathroom, the one that resides in my employer’s house. I walked into his home unannounced while he was with his grandkids, I felt more like an intruder than the UHaul guy

probably did. When I felt I had waited enough, I came back outside only to find the UHaul man waiting for me. I stayed behind the farm stand even when he walked around, craning his neck left and right. My employers left me a silver baseball bat and their phone numbers after that encounter. But when baseball bats aren't necessary there isn't much I can do, and I think that's worse.

My face heats up when Stanley is around, my jaw clenches and it hurts to speak. His veteran hat follows everywhere his pathetic attitude goes. He spits insults about my employers and coworkers. I'm sure he expects a chuckle but I've never understood how they could be funny. I've never been the object of his "jokes" until this year. On this hot day, I was rushing between customers, carrying a bag of recycled boxes that was bigger than me, and assisting those in the middle of shopping as well. As I finished ringing someone up, my coworker asked me to ring Stanley's plants up, she referred to him as a gentleman. The Farm is a family run business, and so Stanley said that he knew I couldn't possibly be related to them because I was too "slow" at my job. I truly am not related. I pulled some more patience out of my back pocket and continued. My only act of vengeance is to refuse to tell him that he must have a good day. One of my coworkers didn't see the point of this and once told me that I couldn't possibly genuinely care that everyone has a good day. And I truly wish you a good day when I say it, as long as you're not Stanley.

Pink is one of my favorite colors. In spite of that, Green Bean Lady's pink lipstick gave me more of a headache than her grumbling did. The neon shade was too bright for her complexion, and her eyeliner sat below her waterline. Considering that it was my third year of employment and I was handed down more responsibility and authority to take over Angela-my coworker- when she wasn't around, I should've been able to handle such a minor complaint.

Unfortunately, I could only stare as this customer informed me that our green beans were atrocious-though she had purchased them several times- and proceeded to tell me that she didn't want free green beans, she wanted *good* green beans. I noted to myself that we had only received praise for the beans, and I was eating them quite often. I glanced around myself, wondering if it was safe to summon my magical bean powers to transform the yield in front of me into the best beans she'd ever had. When I failed to conjure, my boss-who is less nice and less patient-had the pleasure of informing her that she should stop buying the beans if she doesn't like them.

There may be a masochistic aspect to working in customer service, at least for me. If my days at the Farm were only weighing tomatoes with a small glance at the real person before me, never wondering who they may be, or if John who is never not smiling came in every day, would I have much to say? While I believe there is room to discuss the things that give us hope in humanity, I do know it is in my nature to concentrate on the things that suck. Self-torturing in a way that I can peel apart my day to someone, that we may laugh at the things that aren't so great. Because if everything felt fresh, would I appreciate the real good things more? Finding a pearl-rusty or shiny- in a sea of litter feels like a secret you can't help but share. Maybe a polluted ocean isn't that bad when we see the ecosystem at work.

Ode to Fine Arts

The Fine Arts building, over the course of its fifty-five years, holds the most engrossing memories in this world. The memories of everyone who has ever graced its hallways remains captive. Even though I've been long gone, I'm sure it remembers me. From the time I was little, watching in awe and placing myself in the shoes of the people whose feet danced, voices sung, and instruments played on that stage. I wanted to be in their place, expressions through body movements and sound and to perform for a grateful audience. I was ahead of myself in 8th grade and had already joined the high school ensemble, chasing that stage like it could never hurt me.

Fine arts kept me safe that time I had snuck out of lunch period in search of a place like home, only for the intercom to announce a lockdown. The cafeteria was too loud, despite having four different lunch rooms and three different lunch periods, the large room remained crowded. Absolutely sick of sitting by myself with a book in hand, the half hour was suffocating and too long. A few months before, the previous lockdown started with my urgent texts to my mother about the gun and ended with four thousand students rushing home on buses that were several hours early, we didn't even make it past the first class. At least this time, it was during lunch period. Teachers would guard the cafeteria, but I was always good at getting around with the same reused hall pass. Maybe this aspect of cheating was overdue for payback, because I was in the middle of a hallway when they announced the lockdown. With no real place to be, I went the way I knew. Completely unsupervised, I joined a practice room with a few others who had the intent of being productive with instruments in hand, and others like me who were usually bored. We huddled around phones with pictures of the hash slinging slasher, because apparently someone got stabbed in the knee and everyone was too desensitized to not make a joke about it.

Fine arts holds a lot of humiliation as well, I'm not the only one that remembers. It was on the Vincent Macrina stage that I vowed to never touch a piano again. I'm sure it remembers the silence it held for me, in respect to my humiliation. Fingers that once articulated every syncopated note, my left hand in a slow rhythm while my right hand danced. But muscle memory failed me, and the ragtime I felt in my heart became drag time. I played to an audience of two hundred, I played to a live and permanent recording that makes me scream and run away with palms over my ears. I think I placed my hands in a slightly unfamiliar position, and once I started, I couldn't recover from the wrong sounds. I'll never play Dixieland again. No one ever praised me for my piano playing after that. I was self-taught anyway.

Fine arts also holds all of our deepest struggles. The night of the winter concert I had to wash my makeup off and slather on a second, but thicker layer to hide my thin skin. Smudged eyeliner and foundation from crying, but I had to put on a show and put myself together. When I needed to leave home behind, I knew where to go. When I could feel that a seat was empty in the crowd, the lights shined in my eyes so that I wouldn't be able to see. But even before then, when I arrived at Fine Arts in my suit ready to perform cathartically, I sat undisturbed in a practice room until someone walked in and we played heart and soul together. Even though I left home behind and I told no one, I think I was heard that night when my heart and soul was slowly stitched together. Does it remember the echoing dissonance of an untuned piano bouncing off its corkboard walls?

Practice rooms were built with a flimsy material made of holes, I'm sure in an attempt to be sound-proof, but everyone could hear us if we were laughing a little too loud. The walls stained brown in some places, water damage and dusty pianos that hadn't been tuned since the place was built. Our district couldn't spare a dime for our academics, our IB and AP program

was a joke to other schools, so I skipped classes for the underfunded music program because at least we could still sound good without financial investments. Our practice rooms were shrunken and droopy in comparison to Foxborough's pristine and young lesson rooms, but theirs lacked a soul like Fine Arts. At least it remembers that time we knocked the phone off the practice room wall, yet again unsupervised, we panicked. When the ears of the phone are disconnected, it automatically calls the main office. Unfortunately for us, the phone was not reattaching unless we manually held it there, arm straining. I remember the panicked giggling, no one knew what to do when a woman demanded to speak to our teacher. Trying to hold down both my laughter and fear, resolute in the fact that everyone sacrificed me to be the problem solver, I reassured her that we weren't being funny and that it was a complete mistake. But of course, I didn't answer her when she asked who our teacher was. My words were unsteady with laughter while I begged for help to hang up the phone somehow. I know it still sees that the phone handle is still scotch taped to the phone box.

Fine Arts haunts me when I remember that it remembers me. A mix of dread and a great melancholic nostalgia for what once was my life. It's hard to go back and face what we once loved and still do, because going back means you have accepted that the place is no longer yours.

Fiction

MJM

You won't read this, because you clearly don't give a damn anymore. You sent me a heart emoji the night before your wedding. Don't sit here and pretend I don't still mean something. It's why you had to block me on everything. You still think of me. I don't care about your situation, mine is the same. I'm not trying to change anything for either of us. Doesn't it get old playing this game?

Tell me our song.

Tell Me Our Song

Her quotidian had consisted of more sacrifices on her end and a lack of recompensation. A possibly sole comfort was that she was investing, but it only felt like paying in installments with 100% interest.

No matter how quickly she packed her bag and clocked out at 5pm, she managed to arrive home at around 5:35, mind more exhausted than the body. The couch cushions absorbed her. The golden and luminous hour hand from the clock that hung on the wall above her head would tick by faster than the one at the office. Then it would almost be 7:00 and her hunger pushed her off the white cushions in search of a low effort meal.

She was almost in tears tonight, having to get home from work and still having to work and then all she had time to do was go to bed and prepare for the same thing. Almost in tears while frying yuca and jolting every time oil spit at her humiliation. Tears poured out as she wished someone was left in her life. Her hands occupied, she wiped them away with her elbow, but out of the corner of her tear-filled eyes, her phone lit up with a notification. She carefully

laid the plate with steaming mandioca down but flung the rusty metal spatula in the sink because the message must have been work-related and the interruptions were never-ending.

The brightness on her phone was a little too dim, but she squinted and read the interruption: *Tell me our song.* From an unknown number but not an unknown person.

It was hard to admit, but the message was more enticing than nettling. It was pleasing because someone went through the effort—-after being blocked on everything imaginable—-to find her again. Because no matter how much time passed, he couldn't stop thinking about her.

Grabbing her well balanced meal that consisted of rice and mandioca, she crossed the threshold of her room and performed her nightly ritual. Despite having grown up eating all meals at the dinner table, it was unbearable now. During the first few weeks that she started living in her apartment, she had done what she knew and sat at the coffee table in the middle of the kitchen. Practicing what she knew yet feeling strange. At some point, she realized that she could do whatever she wanted. Finally paying her own bills, at least she could make the choice to eat dinner in bed while watching tv on her laptop.

That's when an itch started at her shoulder and rolled down to her fingertips. Out of forgetfulness, not habit, her phone was somewhere in the kitchen, luring her. Her warm bed had already begun to consume her, molding to her body. She told herself that she would only get up once she finished her final forkfull of rice. Looking down at her plate, it seemed to her like there were an awful lot of grains of rice left. Interrupted by urge, she cast her unfinished dinner to the nightstand and made her way to the kitchen.

The kitchen counter lacked a phone and so did the pantry, the cabinets, and the fridge-yes, the fridge was an option and not the weirdest place she had allocated her phone. She even checked the shower, pulled on the curtains and the discolored metal rings that carried the

white lace shower curtains screeched in protest. Just a lackluster drain. In case she brought it to her bedroom unknowingly, she decided to go back. Her phone was beside the dent on her bed that she left behind, beside a bed that was half made with white and gold pillows and tucked sheets on the left side. Somehow, she must have not even noticed it. She picked it up eagerly.

You won't read this, because you clearly don't give a damn anymore.

She rolled her eyes and scoffed at the self-absorbed and attention-seeking text.

The wind howled at her in response, chastising her lack of pity. Two messages within twenty eight minutes in the evening. Clearly, someone was having a rough night, and it wasn't her.

Finally settled again she resumed the documentary but the wind yelled louder than the television and the dim lamp at her bedside flickered. A moment of silence and waiting. The tv shut off as did the dim lights. She ran her hands through her hair and got up for the second time to find a lighter and candles with her phone screen light because the flashlight had finally stopped working after being dropped down the stairs a few too many times.

She stubbed her toe on furniture and the pain had her limping and shouting, "I hope you're happy!"

Scrounging blindly in the spare drawer her hand gripped cool metal. Her finger flicked and flicked the rough wheel and an insignificant flame would briefly make an appearance, not long enough to burn the fresh wick as it fizzled out. She plopped down on the floor. Her phone screen lit up in her hand once again, but not of her own doing.

Don't sit here and pretend I don't still mean something.

She smiled.

But the messages kept flowing, and it wasn't funny anymore.

It's why you had to block me on everything. You still think of me.

It was an accusation at worst and a lie at best. Most nights she thought about the life that she was tight around her ring finger, a weight that was promised to her but taken away despite in sickness and in health. On rare nights, she thought about the white lace adorning her arms down to her wrists that were ripped with a forceful yank because of him.

Even now, she didn't entertain the thought. It only brought about waves of misery and regret from a deserving future seized from her.

You sent me a heart emoji the night before your wedding. Doesn't it get old playing this game?

Only if you lingered on the same person for too long, which was her first mistake.

A beginning and an end: *Tell me our song.*

The entrance music was destined to be her beginning, but she hadn't even gotten that chance. Months of deciding which piece was the perfect symbol and perfect melody. It was all that she could think of, all she could hear when she thought of that time in her life. A side quest, an intervening relief; associating him with a song would call for permanence. There would be no room for that in her future, only occasional and temporary excitement to fall back on; in case her marriage came with stagnancy along with stability.

Unlucky that morning, her sub plot came rushing in, flipping over tables coated in white, smashing the ceremonial wine glass, tearing apart the ring cushion. The cake spatula lost its shine, the ring dulled, and the candles appeared more eerie than celebratory.

~~~

Tell me our song.
~~~

While the wind raged outside, the darkness fell in shadows around the door to her apartment. He knocked on the door to collect retribution.

~~~

Because of her forgetfulness or perhaps her lack of care, she couldn't remember the song nor the phone in her hand when a knock pounded at her door. Or maybe it was the vaguely familiar melody through the cracks of the front door that came first and made her forget rather than remember the phone or song. Released from her grasp, her phone fell to the floor with a final crack that plunged her into a musical yet complete darkness.

Raw

In a performative but ritualistic oval shape sat his friends with crossed legs, beginning to look unrecognizable with their sadistic greed. Truth or Dare: pinnacle of an anxiety that prevented his eyes from meeting anyone else's, made his Adam's apple bob in anticipation as he watched the Deliverer's flesh colored lips form words that hadn't yet registered. Like lightning before thunder and he was running out of time. Dreadful options but his heart pounded along with the choosing timer. Everyone got one minute but the seconds on his ? were faster and he no longer remembered if the timer started at sixty or thirty.
~~~

There isn't much to fear about an involuntary act until you are surrounded by those who know you well enough to torture your vulnerabilities. His phobia was silly and he knew it, but worse was that it was real and everyone knew it. Once they bestowed his sentence, everyone in the circle stood up, walked to the fridge and watched the Deliverer pull out a container that held a thawed, raw steak that must have been prepared for him.

Nothing short of ceremonial, the Deliverer grabbed a white, flat plate and slapped the meat onto it, squelching and splashing red juices onto his cheeks. Mimicking a crime scene, the Deliverer laid a knife in front of him, blank faces leering at him. The others leaned forward and gripped the counter, for a show of predation.

No one held a gun to his head, and yet with the promise of a Truth dangling over his head, his heart couldn't tell the difference between this and a mortal threat. So with steady hands, he picked up the steak knife and began to saw through the raw meat, which eerily couldn't be heard over his beating heart. It didn't matter because his imagination compensated, and it sounded a lot like tearing through flesh while the animal's body convulsed and twitched. The fingers attached to his hand met the wetness, the squishiness and suddenly he was gagging. A hand gripped his wrist and pushed it toward his face, the meat got closer and the smell of death permeated the air. It slipped from his grip. There was red on his hands that he feared would never dry brown.

Fear. Because he knew what they would ask if he failed. Fear. Because it did not matter if he lied or not. Fear. Because he could not even hold his own composure under his second greatest nightmare. Fear. Because he was about to live his first one.

It is nature to eat, it is nature to kill for hunger. And the creatures of the earth circled him like sharks as he slumped over the trash can, because it is in nature to prey on the weakest. A nature that he comprehended but failed to execute. It was a kill or be killed world, and he didn't have a choice.

With his head bowed over his victim in his cupped hand, blurry faces were all but flashes of yellow teeth that achingly watched him bring death to his lips, all for a taste.

Poetry

Swims

Sealess saltwater, but I still can't open my eyes

Might I turn down and flip up

Into the upside down fighting against back-

Wards. Water breaks, my face crashes

Shore is outside and she's in.

Swims
Dive in and breathe in
Suffocate on complacency
Motionless, suspended, you're akin
To an image of hope, can you see?

That you're bromine
Pooling into a whirl
Wasted effort against the currents
But at least you feel clean
Scream.
and kick your legs
You're not getting anywhere
Dream.
of a perennial stream

Behind and where have you been
Swims beneath skin
But you just
Don't.

Dichotomic Mind and Organ

I am under your skin
Prickling needles and pins
Follow my stagger, my hum, my rather
Humble ways to show a love that truly
matters

I crawl beneath you, raising bumps along
flesh
Stretching your transparent mesh
Breathing songs that make you go red
Thumping in your ear against the bed

I pour every last drop
A never ending cycle of
Waves that consume sand and spit out foam
As long as you remain like a wind mill

Spin spin spin
Breath take Breathe take
In Breathe Out Breath

I pump but sometimes I stutter and lump
Your surroundings might excite me
Flowing like a winter stream, so cold it bites
Or they may lull you into a hibernating
slumber

You confuse me when you sprint in place
I go faster but you are slower
Absent from a race, I lower down your body
You delude me into a chase that doesn't
exist

Suspended upside, I move where I shall
Through a canal where you are lost
In mist you deceive me and I deceive you
Believe me

I receive grey bubbles of panic
As organic as I am, I see artificial lies
Narrate for me you unreliable wretch
Here's the sketch: